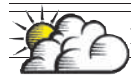


The Washington Post

Prices may vary in areas outside metropolitan Washington.

SU V1 V2 V3 V4



Partly sunny 37/22 • Tomorrow: Cloudy, cold 30/23 **B6**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, FEBRUARY 18, 2025 • \$4

Federal workers detail chaotic, error-filled firings

BY HANNAH NATANSON,
LISA REIN
AND EMILY DAVIES

The first message from her manager on Saturday afternoon misspelled Amanda Mae Downey's name. The second mentioned "the news" about probationary federal workers, and how the Trump administration planned to fire them.

When Downey called her boss at a Michigan branch of the U.S. Forest Service for an explanation, she learned her name was on a firing list. She would have to come

Many targeted by Trump had excellent employee performance reviews

into the office to sign a letter formalizing her termination. And she had to do it before the holiday weekend was over.

"I'm glad that our agency at least has decided we can do it in person," her manager said, according to a recording Downey provided to The Washington Post. "So we

can add a little human touch to what's going on."

Many federal government employees were dismissed over the holiday weekend as managers confronted a Trump administration demand to fire workers by Tuesday. In group texts and in online forums, they dubbed the error-ridden run of firings the "St. Valentine's Day Massacre."

The firings targeted new hires on probation, who have fewer protections than permanent employees, and swept up people with years of service who had recently transferred between agencies, as

well as military veterans and people with disabilities employed through a program that sped their hiring but put them on two years' probation. Most probationary employees have limited rights to appeal dismissals, but union heads have vowed to challenge the mass firings in court. The largest union representing federal workers has

SEE **FEDERAL WORKERS** ON **A7**

Weak guardrails: Shake-up has stunned many in civil service. **A4**

By the numbers: A graphical guide to the federal workforce. **A6**



MATT MCCLAIN/THE WASHINGTON POST

Protesters gather near the United States Capitol Reflecting Pool on Monday to protest President Donald Trump and Elon Musk.

Europeans consider troops in Ukraine

Leaders sound out U.S. support for deterrence as ceasefire talks accelerate

BY ELLEN FRANCIS

BRUSSELS — European leaders held an urgently arranged meeting Monday in part to discuss the potential deployment of their troops to Ukraine under a ceasefire deal, as contacts accelerate between the United States and Russia over halting the war.

The Trump administration has been seeking to learn what forces and weapons European countries could commit, while the Europeans, for their part, have been sounding out the Trump team about what kind of military backing would be available, for instance intelligence or air defenses.

The prospect of deploying troops to Ukraine has gained traction among some European leaders in recent days as the Trump administration has moved quickly toward opening direct negotiations with Moscow. Ukraine's European backers are scrambling for a role in the talks, which are advancing without them but could reshape the continent's security landscape. U.S. and Russian officials are expected to meet in Saudi Arabia on Tuesday.

French President Emmanuel Macron convened a meeting of

SEE **UKRAINE** ON **A17**

In Riyadh: Trump's team prepares to kick off talks with Russia. **A16**

Steve Witkoff: Friend at the heart of Trump's foreign diplomacy. **A16**

Passenger plane flips during landing at Toronto airport



COLE BURSTON/REUTERS

A Delta Air Lines regional jet lies upside down after crashing Monday afternoon at Toronto Pearson International Airport. Eighteen passengers were taken to hospitals, Delta said, but all 80 people who were on board the flight had survived as of Monday evening. Canadian and U.S. authorities are investigating the incident. **Story, A2**

As troops arrive, few migrants crossing border

BY ARELIS R. HERNÁNDEZ

DEL RIO, TEXAS — There are signs all over town that the troops have arrived.

The two hotels closest to the Border Patrol headquarters are sold out. A local gym and a barber-shop are advertising discounts for men and women in uniform. And every Thursday, diners can use

their military IDs to save on food and drinks at Molcajetes Mexican restaurant.

Several hundred active-duty troops arrived in the Texas city of Del Rio in late January after President Donald Trump declared an invasion and ordered troops to deploy to the southern border. The U.S. Defense Department says 3,600 servicemen and service-

women, mostly from the U.S. Army and Marines, have been sent to help patrol the nation's land border with Mexico.

But their arrival comes at one of the quietest moments at the border in the past decade. Agents with the Border Patrol sector that includes Del Rio and the neighboring city of Eagle Pass have been apprehending fewer than 50 peo-

ple per day since late January. That's a stark decline from 2023, when as many as 5,000 migrants surrendered to agents daily after crossing the Rio Grande.

Locals say they welcome the tax revenue and extra boots on the ground. But it's not clear to them why they are needed now.

"We're glad they're here enjoy-
SEE **BORDER** ON **A8**

2026 Games will bring world together — sort of

The Milan-Cortina Winter Olympics will shatter the mold with events held in seven far-flung villages

BY LES CARPENTER

MILAN — The 2026 Milan-Cortina Winter Olympics, which will be entering their second week one year from now, will be the most spread-out Games ever, stretching hundreds of miles across the Italian Alps from Milan to the borders of Switzerland and Austria. The trip between the men's and women's downhill skiing venues alone could take up to 12 hours.

Past Winter Olympics were confined to one or two places with indoor sports such as figure skating and hockey based in a city and the outdoor competitions on mountains a reasonable drive away, making it possible to attend events at both sites in a single day.

The 2026 Games will disman-



MARCO BERTORELLO/AGENCE FRANCE-PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

Having Rasen-Antholz and other Alps villages serve as venues for the 2026 Milano-Cortina Games creates major logistical problems.

tle that concept with venues spread across seven mountain villages reached only by narrow, winding roads and connected by a mix of trains and shuttle buses that will make the trips take hours.

The sprawling plan is an attempt by organizers to control costs by limiting the building of new facilities and to take advantage of Italy's best ski slopes and courses. But it also creates logistical challenges never confronted at a Winter Olympics.

Among them: two Olympic cauldron lighting ceremonies in cities 125 miles apart. Multiple improvised Athletes' Villages instead of one for the city and one for the mountain. Men's and women's Alpine skiing events on separate slopes for the first time,
SEE **OLYMPICS** ON **A12**

Trump casts psychiatric drugs as threat to children

BY FENIT NIRAPPIL,
ARIANA EUNJUNG CHA
AND CAITLIN GILBERT

President Donald Trump has instructed his administration to scrutinize the "threat" to children posed by antidepressants, stimulants and other common psychiatric drugs, targeting medication taken by millions in his latest challenge to long-standing medical practices.

The directive came in an executive order Thursday that established a "Make America Healthy Again" commission led by Health and Human Services Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr., who has criticized the use of those drugs and issued false claims about them.

The order said the commission should prepare a "Make Our Chil-

dren Healthy Again" assessment within 100 days that examines "the prevalence of and threat posed by the prescription of selective serotonin reuptake inhibitors, antipsychotics, mood stabilizers, stimulants, and weight-loss drugs." The directive comes as children and teens endure a mental health crisis exacerbated by the coronavirus pandemic.

Kennedy also has made childhood nutrition and healthful food a signature issue. He has been critical of the boom in weight-loss drugs such as Ozempic, Wegovy, Zepbound and Mounjaro.

The medication review joins a slew of Trump administration policies upending the government's approach to health, many of which are embroiled in legal
SEE **DRUGS** ON **A5**

IN THE NEWS

Pet peeves President Donald Trump has ordered sweeping changes in his first weeks back in office, but his efforts have also focused on smaller grievances. **A3**

Mauí's recovery Only six homes have been fully rebuilt in the county after a 2023 wildfire that burned more than 2,000 structures. **A22**

THE NATION
A Las Vegas lawyer who called himself a "gorilla pimp" was charged with sexually exploiting his clients. **A2**
A 104-year-old woman got her birthday wish — a trip to jail. **A2**

THE WORLD
The equestrian sport of buzkashi is thriving in Afghanistan under the Taliban. **A9**
Pope Francis will remain in the hospital for a "complex" respiratory infection. **A11**

THE ECONOMY
Elon Musk mischaracterized a government contract as he accused the Reuters news agency of "social deception." **A18**
The SEC backed off a rule requiring large companies to disclose their greenhouse gas emissions and plans to reduce them. **A18**

THE REGION
Virginia lawmakers are concerned about data centers but may spend another session without taking action. **B1**
Testimony in the trial of the owner of a D.C. rowhouse where a 2019 fire killed two renters is set to enter its third and final week. **B1**

STYLE
We spent time with three New York-based designers to see what the city's once-flourishing garment industry looks like now. **C1**

HEALTH & SCIENCE
In two states, property owners are offering space to terminally ill people who are ready to die. **E1**

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